AI Employee Leave Assistant: Requirements, SLIs, SLOs and SLA

Version 1.0 (draft). All numeric targets are illustrative starting points, not industry standards. Adjust them to your organization.

1. Purpose and scope

The AI Employee Leave Assistant is a chat assistant that lets employees check leave balances, apply for, edit and cancel leave, ask leave-policy questions, and view holidays and approval status. The HR system remains the single source of truth. The assistant never invents a balance and never approves leave on its own.

In scope

- Leave balance lookup
- Apply, edit and cancel leave
- Policy questions and answers
- Holiday calendar
- Approval status and routing to the manager

Out of scope (handed off to HR)

- Policy exceptions and disputes
- Medical or legal advice
- Payroll changes

2. Definitions

Term	Plain meaning	Who it is for
Business requirement	What the business needs, in plain words	Stakeholders
SLI (service level indicator)	A measurement: a number you can track	Engineers

Term	Plain meaning	Who it is for
SLO (service level objective)	The internal target for that measurement	Engineering team
SLA (service level agreement)	A contract with consequences if broken	Customers, legal, vendors
Error budget	The amount of failure allowed by an SLO (100% minus the target)	Engineering team

The chain: business requirement, then SLI, then SLO, then SLA. Each step makes the previous one more precise. The SLO should be stricter than the SLA so problems are caught before a penalty applies.

3. Business requirements

ID	Requirement
BR1	Employees get correct balances and policy answers without contacting HR.
BR2	An employee can apply for, change or cancel leave in a single conversation.
BR3	Every request follows approval rules (manager, overlap and blackout dates). None are bypassed.
BR4	Responses feel instant in chat.
BR5	The assistant is reliably available across working hours in every region.
BR6	Employees see only their own data, and managers see only their reports' data.
BR7	Every action is auditable.
BR8	Anything the assistant cannot handle reaches a human.

4. SLIs (what we measure)

SLI	How it is measured
Answer accuracy	Share of policy and balance answers that match the HR system or policy, checked on a graded sample
Action success rate	Completed correct actions divided by attempted actions
Wrong-action rate	Leave created or cancelled that the employee did not intend
Time to first token (TTFT)	Time from sending a message to the first word of the reply, at p95
End-to-end action time	Time from request to confirmed action, at p95
Availability	Successful requests divided by all requests
Guardrail violations	Requests that broke approval or policy rules
Access violations	Any case of data shown to the wrong person
Audit completeness	Actions with a log entry divided by all actions
Containment	Conversations resolved without an HR ticket
CSAT	Share of thumbs-up ratings

5. SLOs (internal targets)

SLI	SLO	Serves
Availability	99.9% per 30 days (about 43 minutes of downtime allowed)	BR5
TTFT, p95	Under 2 seconds	BR4
End-to-end action time, p95	Under 8 seconds	BR4

SLI	SLO	Serves
Answer accuracy	At least 97% on a weekly sample. Balances are read from the HR system, never from the model's memory.	BR1
Action success rate	At least 98%	BR2
Wrong-action rate	At most 0.1%	BR2
Guardrail violations	0	BR3
Access violations	0	BR6
Audit completeness	100%	BR7
Containment	At least 80%	BR1, BR8
CSAT	At least 85%	BR1

The zero-tolerance rows are not error-budget items. A single violation triggers an incident.

6. SLA (the promise with consequences)

This applies if HR, IT or a vendor commits to the company or its employees.

- **Availability:** 99.5% per month. This is looser than the 99.9% SLO so problems are caught before a credit is owed.
- **Service credits (example):** below 99.5%, 10% of the monthly fee. Below 99%, 25%.
- **Support:** severity-1 incidents get a response within 1 hour.
- **Data protection:** no cross-user data exposure, with breach notification within a contract-defined window.
- **Exclusions:** planned maintenance, HR system outages (the assistant depends on them), and invalid user input.

Answer accuracy is deliberately kept out of the SLA. It is hard to guarantee for a language model, so it is tracked as an SLO only.

7. How they connect

Business requirement	SLI	SLO	In SLA?
BR1 Correct answers	Answer accuracy	At least 97%	No
BR4 Feels instant	TTFT p95	Under 2 seconds	No
BR5 Reliable	Availability	99.9%	Yes, 99.5% with credits
BR6 Privacy	Access violations	0	Yes, no-exposure clause
BR7 Auditable	Audit completeness	100%	Optional

8. Design rules that make these targets achievable

1. The model calls tools for balances and actions. It does not answer from memory.
2. It confirms details back to the user before submitting, for example: "Annual leave, 3 to 5 Nov, 3 days. Submit?"
3. It checks the user's identity and role on every tool call.
4. It hands off to HR, with the conversation attached, when confidence is low.
5. Every action writes an audit log entry.